

Audit Blog Topics Against the Product Catalog

OBJECTIVE

Produce a written verdict on every topic in the blog program — published, planned, and newsletter-only — recording which product or category page it routes to and which CTA it asks for. Topics that cannot name one get killed or re-aimed, and the calendar is re-seeded from the catalog outward. Half a day for the inventory and the sort, plus a working session with whoever owns the editorial calendar. The output is a shorter calendar and a standing gate, not a report.

KEY STEPS

1. **List every topic, including the ones the blog team does not own.** Published posts, the planned calendar, and topics that only appear in the email newsletter — that is where the worst offenders live.
2. **Name the destination page and the CTA for each topic.** One URL, one action, two columns. Not “awareness,” not “the brand.” This column is the whole audit.
3. **Run the two tests on everything that failed step 2, in order.** Can you rank — *“that’s a really saturated world... extremely competitive to try to rank for?”* And if you did, would it matter — *“if you do, it’s never gonna do anything for you. Like it has nothing to do with your product catalog.”*
4. **Disqualify the email click as a defence.** *“you might get some random clicks in the email campaign you sent out ‘cause it’s just eye-catching enough.”* Universal appeal earns the open and guarantees the saturation. Keep engagement in its own column where it cannot stand in for the CTA.
5. **Redirect the survivors, kill the rest.** Hoot’s fix is re-aiming, not a purge: *“redirect their blog topics and other content topics to be like where really completely relates to their CTA.”* Keep URLs that carry links or history; re-scope the piece. (*inferred: 301 vs rewrite is per URL, not her prescription.*)
6. **Re-seed one product or category at a time — as articles, not FAQ blocks.** *“it’s limitless the types of in depth blog articles... That’s much better than an FAQ block at the bottom of the product page.”* These catch the ready-to-buy reader too, at a conversion rate below the product page but on far more volume.
7. **Confirm real demand before anything is written.** Pull question-shaped queries from Search Console, Semrush’s Questions report and Ahrefs for the topic, not just the domain — that stored question data is *“the predecessor”* for how people now prompt Claude and ChatGPT. Treat each question as the head of a branch. Nothing gets written that has not cleared this step.
8. **Put the SEO owner in the topic-selection meeting, permanently.** *“the SEO folks, we work directly with that team to help curate topics and make sure they’re ranking. And those blogs convert.”* Curate, not review. The audit is a one-off; the seat is the fix.

CAUTIONARY NOTES

- **Answer the footprint question first.** The audit inverts for one location: *“even if you’re ranking nationally, you’re getting somebody in New York and but you’re a vet clinic in Austin.”* That budget usually belongs in local media and community links.
- **Not a ban on top-of-funnel.** The test is the line to the catalog, not the funnel stage. A lifestyle article routing to a shippable product passes step 2 cleanly.
- **A traffic gain is not proof it worked.** Diff the query set, not the total (Jeremy Rivera): *“just because you rank for something, it doesn’t mean that it necessarily matches up cleanly with a... commercial intent or a visibility intent or audience intent.”*
- **“Quality over quantity” is a selection rule, not an output cap.** A large multi-category catalog supports far more genuinely useful articles than the slogan implies.
- **Re-aiming a topic does not fix the page the CTA points at.** Separate work, separate owner — but now on a much shorter list.

TIPS FOR EFFICIENCY

- Sort on the step-2 column before arguing about anything. Names a page, or does not. That split is most of the audit, in an afternoon.
- Kill the seasonal and holiday topics first — fastest, least contested, and it buys credibility for the arguable ones.
- Semrush’s Questions view is the fastest re-seed input; Search Console is the most defensible, because it is your own demand rather than a modelled estimate.
- Keep the sheet as a standing gate, not a finished audit. Every new topic gets a destination page and a CTA before it gets a writer.
- Run the session *with* the content team. Delivered to them it reads as a critique; run with them it becomes the seat in step 8.

“I’d rather have 10 visits with two converting than thousands and thousands with nobody converting.” — Laura Hoot